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The Codebreakers

Fear and hatred are the emotions that hackers normally evoke. But there are two kinds of this breed as well. Meet the ethical kind

Meera Vankipuram

The word 'hacker' conjures up an image: an evil person keen on disrupting systems for fun's sake—and so that he (a hacker is usually a 'he') can boast to his friends about the systems he's breached. The term 'ethical hacker', may, therefore sound like an oxymoron.

However, 'ethical hackers' do exist, and these masters of their craft are the mirror image of what people think of hackers. They possess pretty much the same skill set, but use them for the exact opposite reason—to identify vulnerabilities in systems so that corrective action may be taken.

The term 'hacker' originally referred to those involved in creating a new program or making changes to existing, complex software.

Ethical hackers employ the same tools and techniques as malicious hackers, or 'crackers', but they do not damage the target systems, nor steal information. They test networks for vulnerabili-

ties, evaluate systems' security practices and report loopholes as well as remedial measures to the owners.

They can perform security audits for companies—testing a system for vulnerabilities and submitting a report. This kind of work may not even require the services of an ethical hacker per se. Alternatively, they could actually attack a security system, seek out the vulnerabilities that a malicious hacker could easily exploit and, of course, report or fix them.

India's 'underground overlords' of the IT realm are nestled in small—mostly, home—offices in the quiet suburbs of Mumbai, Delhi and several other cities across the country. These codebreakers and security experts are busy scouring networks to seek and destroy vulnerabilities.

Ethical hacker Shomiron Das Gupta, a Certified Information System Security Professional (CISSP) and GIAC Certified Intrusion Analyst (SANS Certified), was formerly employed with ICICI InfoTech as a security consultant, before

In the business of security (L to R): Shomiron Das Gupta (CISSP), Jagdish Mahapatra (BDM, Cisco Systems), KK Mookhey (CISA)



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